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Personality-Relationship Transactions Revisited

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Abstract

The transactional paradigm states that people create, maintain, and change their environments according to their personalities. At the same time, the environment reacts back on personality. As social relationships are part of an individual's environment, this likewise implies that there are reciprocal transactions between personality and relationships. However, earlier studies have concluded that adult personality traits are so stable that they have a stronger effect on later relationships, but that relationship effects on personality are negligible. In this article, we contend that personality-relationship transactions should be revisited. We submit that the relative powers of personality versus relationship effects depend on the type of life transition during which the effects take place: Relationship effects on personality development are more likely to emerge in the context of rather normative and highly scripted life transitions, whereas personality effects on relationship development are more likely to occur in the context of rather non-normative life transitions that are less regulated by social expectations. We illustrate these assumptions with examples from our own work and other findings reported in the literature. Furthermore, we theorize that effects of personality-relationship transactions on health also vary with the normativeness of the eliciting life transition.

Individual lifestyles and circumstances are typically expressed in the social networks in which people are embedded. Consequently, social networks are key features of personal environments. People actively seek out, create, and change their social relationships in ways that suit their personalities. Nonetheless, people are influenced or even lastingly changed by experiences with relationship partners such as parents, siblings, children, peers, or romantic partners who become particularly important in certain phases of life. These dynamic processes are called personality-relationship transactions. The concept of personality-relationship transaction is tied in with the fundamental premise of a transactional perspective on personality development, which assumes continuous and reciprocal interactions between one's personality and the environment across the life course (Neyer & Asendorpf, 2001). In this article, we submit that such transactions are powerful mechanisms of personality development and related health outcomes. Innovatively, we argue that relationship effects on personality and personality effects on relationships have different strengths depending on the life transitions during which they take place.

For example, relationships with peers are very important for children once they enter kindergarten or preschool, and this is why peers at this age are thought to play a powerful role in personality development (e.g., Harris, 1995). After childhood, the impact of peers as socialization agents decreases, as relationships with peers are rather selected and maintained in accordance with one's individual purposes (e.g., Back, Schmukle, & Egloff, 2011; Hill, Payne, Jackson, Stine-Morrow, & Roberts, 2013; Selfhout et al., 2010). This example of peer relationships illustrates that the interplay of personality and relationships is likely to change across the life course and to trigger how people adapt to the diverging challenges they face in their lives. At the same time, it is also impressive that people remain who they are (i.e., personality is quite stable; Roberts & DelVecchio, 2000) despite the various transitions that may challenge them. This implies that life transitions do not necessarily result in change but may also foster stability.

To gain a deeper understanding of whether and how social relationships contribute to both personality change and stability, it seems reasonable to take into account the life transitions that constitute the social framework of personality-relationship transactions. Caspi and Moffitt (1993) proposed a paradoxical theory of personality coherence, which states that most

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external and atypical discontinuities in life (i.e., rather non-normative life experiences or transitions) tend to stabilize individual differences in personality traits. By contrast, other expected, age-graded discontinuities (i.e., rather normative life experiences or transitions) may have the potential to catalyze personality change because they entail strong pressures and provide clear advice about how to behave adaptively. These latter transitions may set personality change in motion, whereas, somewhat paradoxically, the non-normative transitions may be ambiguous and unforeseeable and may therefore be better managed by the personalities that people bring to them. Against the background of Caspi and Moffitt's theory, we submit the hypothesis that the relative strengths of personality and relationship effects vary with the *normativeness* of life transitions. In particular, we assume that relationship effects on personality should increase with the normativeness of life transitions, whereas personality effects on relationships should be stronger in less normative transitions.

This article is organized as follows: In the first part, we discuss the normativeness of life transitions and how these transitions relate to lifelong personality and relationship development. Second, we propose a revised perspective on personality-relationship transactions, present preliminary evidence, and submit testable hypotheses that future research may wish to address. Third, we discuss how personality-relationship transactions may affect adaptive personality development and related health outcomes. Finally, we will present some methodological considerations to complete the revisited concept of personality-relationship transactions.

LIFE TRANSITIONS AS CONTEXTS OF PERSONALITY AND SOCIAL RELATIONSHIP DEVELOPMENT

Normativeness of Life Transitions

Life transitions are usually classified as either normative or non-normative changes in life circumstances. Hereby, we argue that such changes are too complex to be simply divided into two distinct categories of life transitions and suggest instead that *normativeness* be considered as a continuum. Different degrees of normativeness depend on two criteria. First, life transitions vary to the extent that they occur mandatorily within a given sociocultural context and a certain age range. Compared to less normative transitions, more normative ones are characterized by a greater amount of age gradation, and their occurrence is presumed to be only slightly affected by self-selection effects (Lang, Reschke, & Neyer, 2006). Second, transitions vary to the extent that they are furnished by social expectations or social scripts that are shared among members of a reference group, that is, peers of the same age in a given (sub)population. In contrast to less normative transitions, it is the scripted nature of rather normative transitions that calls for individuals to change (Caspi & Moffitt, 1993; Roberts, Wood, & Smith, 2005; Snyder & Ickes, 1985). It can be expected that many of the common life transitions, such as partnering, parenting, or entering the labor market, are rather age-graded and scripted, which means that both criteria of normativeness are met equally. There are also exceptions to this rule. For example, becoming a Catholic priest or entering a convent is definitely not an age-graded experience. Yet, for young men belonging to the reference group of novices, it is very well a shared experience that is scripted by strong behavioral guidelines.

Rather normative transitions occur at specific times and are constrained by social clocks. For example, Specht, Egloff, and Schmukle (2011) described the normative sequence of typical events with data from a large representative German sample—mean ages at first job: 21.2 ($SD = 4.9$), birth of a child: 31.1 ($SD = 6.7$), marriage: 34.2 ($SD = 10.2$), separation from partner: 35.6 ($SD = 11.2$), children leaving home: 49.7 ($SD = 7.7$), death of spouse: 65.9 ($SD = 10.3$). At the same time, these data and the large standard deviations illustrate that people differ not only with regard to whether they experience these life transitions, but also when and in what order. Ranking life transitions according to their degree of normativeness is a difficult task because the incidence rate of a specific life transition within a certain age range depends on the reference group. For example, marriage in some areas of Germany is nowadays less normative compared to specific areas in other countries, such as the United States, or compared to Germany in the 1950s. Furthermore, the degree to which certain life experiences are equipped with explicit social scripts will also vary with both the historical and societal contexts under study: In general, German wives and husbands nowadays face different expectations compared to earlier times and compared to other cultural contexts.

To date, there is no existing taxonomy that allows for life transitions to be classified according to the extent to which they conform to expectations regarding the age at which they occur or the behaviors associated with them. Whereas life course sociologists have highlighted that societies define normative ages for life transitions and thus constrain life course patterns (Mayer, 2009), psychologists have rarely investigated how individuals differ in how they perceive life transitions according to their normativeness (e.g., Rubin, Berntsen, & Hutson, 2009). A comprehensive taxonomy of life transitions should consider at least three further aspects. First, societal and historical changes may influence normativeness with respect to the occurrence of certain life transitions (e.g., declining marriage rates or increasing rates of childlessness and divorce in some European societies). Second, behavioral scripts may also undergo historical changes and depend upon both the respective society and the specific reference group (e.g., changed gender roles in parenting and at the workplace). Third, within any societal and historical context, the normativeness of life transitions might further be affected by their timing and the order in which they are experienced (e.g., late partnering or parenting before partnering).

Personality Development

Personality development is characterized by high rank-order stability (Roberts & DelVecchio, 2000), small but significant mean-level changes (Roberts, Walton, & Viechtbauer, 2006), and substantial individual differences regarding the direction, rate, and time of personality change (e.g., Neyer & Lehnart, 2007). Meta-analytic and large-scale longitudinal studies have consistently shown that many changes take place during young adulthood (Lucas & Donnellan, 2011; Roberts et al., 2006), when people become more emotionally stable, agreeable, and conscientious. Throughout this article, we refer to personality change in terms of *differential change* (i.e., individual differences in change), which combines mean-level and rank-order perspectives, for example, between-group differences in mean-level changes or within-group attenuations of rank-order stability. By personality stability, on the other hand, we always refer to an individual's relative standing within a population or group, irrespective of possible mean-level changes.

There is evidence that some changes in personality are associated with more normative life transitions: Figure 1 (Panel A) summarizes Specht and colleagues' (2011) results, which show that personality change accompanies certain life transitions such as job entry or marriage. Because we now know that the mechanisms accounting for personality change have both genetic and environmental sources (Bleidorn, Kandler, Riemann, Angleitner, & Spinath, 2009; Kandler et al., 2010), the following questions arise: Which kinds of situations have the potential to set personality changes in motion, and which are more prone to being shaped by personality traits? We suggest that personality-relationship transactions can open a door for investigating these questions.

Two established principles of personality development contribute to the understanding of environmental influences on personality development across the life course: the *social investment principle* and the *corresponsive principle*. The social investment principle says that taking over age-graded social roles is the driving force of personality change (Roberts et al., 2005), and this applies especially to young adulthood. Becoming a loving partner, a caring parent, or a reliable workmate reflects societal expectations and thus constitutes normative transitions. These transitions are shared by most members of a reference group and "promote a reward structure that calls for becoming more socially dominant, agreeable, conscientious and less neurotic" (p. 174). Individual differences in the commitment to social roles contribute to differential personality development (Lodi-Smith & Roberts, 2007).

Differential personality development is also at the core of the corresponsive principle, which states that certain life experiences accentuate the traits that led to them in the first place (Roberts, Caspi, & Moffitt, 2003). Life experiences do not always arise randomly but are at least partly predictable by characteristics of the individual person, which are in turn further shaped by those experiences. In other words, selection and socialization effects are not necessarily independent of each other. We hypothesize that the corresponsive principle particularly applies to less normative life experiences that are not shared by the majority of people in the same reference group but are rather subject to self-selection processes.

Residential mobility, for instance, is still a less normative life transition, which people may choose at least in part by virtue of their personalities (Jokela, 2009). In a prospective control group study with German university students, Zimmermann and Neyer (2013) observed that long-term sojourner students (i.e., students who attended campuses abroad for at least one academic year) differed from control students (i.e., students who stayed at their local universities) in that they already had higher levels of openness to experience before the transition to study abroad took place (selection effect). During their stay, these sojourners tended to become even more open (socialization effect).

The study by Zimmermann and Neyer (2013) is one among the few that have found empirical support for the strict assumption of the corresponsive principle by showing that the expression of a particular trait predisposes people for a certain life transition, and that it is this particular trait that in turn becomes accentuated. The pioneering study by Roberts et al. (2003) provides another classical example by showing that the personality trait of dominance selected people into jobs that involved power, and employment in such jobs further increased their levels of dominance.

To summarize, the social investment and corresponsive principles promote different perspectives on personality development. The social investment principle predicts socialization effects of rather normative life experiences on personality development. Conversely, the corresponsive principle assumes that selection effects of personality and socialization effects of relationships complement each other in the context of less normative life experiences and contribute to the cumulative continuity of individual differences across the life course. In other words, the social investment principle sets out to explain why personality changes in a certain direction, whereas the corresponsive principle explains why personality becomes more and more consistent despite the various circumstances that may challenge people's lives. However, exceptions to this rule of thumb abound as normative transitions do also allow for a certain degree of variability regarding whether and when individuals invest in social roles (Lodi-Smith & Roberts, 2007). As all kinds of life transitions are mostly characterized by changes in social relationships, we will discuss below how patterns of relationship development are associated with personality development in the context of both rather normative and non-normative life experiences.

Social Relationship Development

The psychology of social relationships represents a much more heterogeneous field than personality psychology. It is certainly common sense that different types of relationships exist, such as those with genetic relatives, with peers, or with

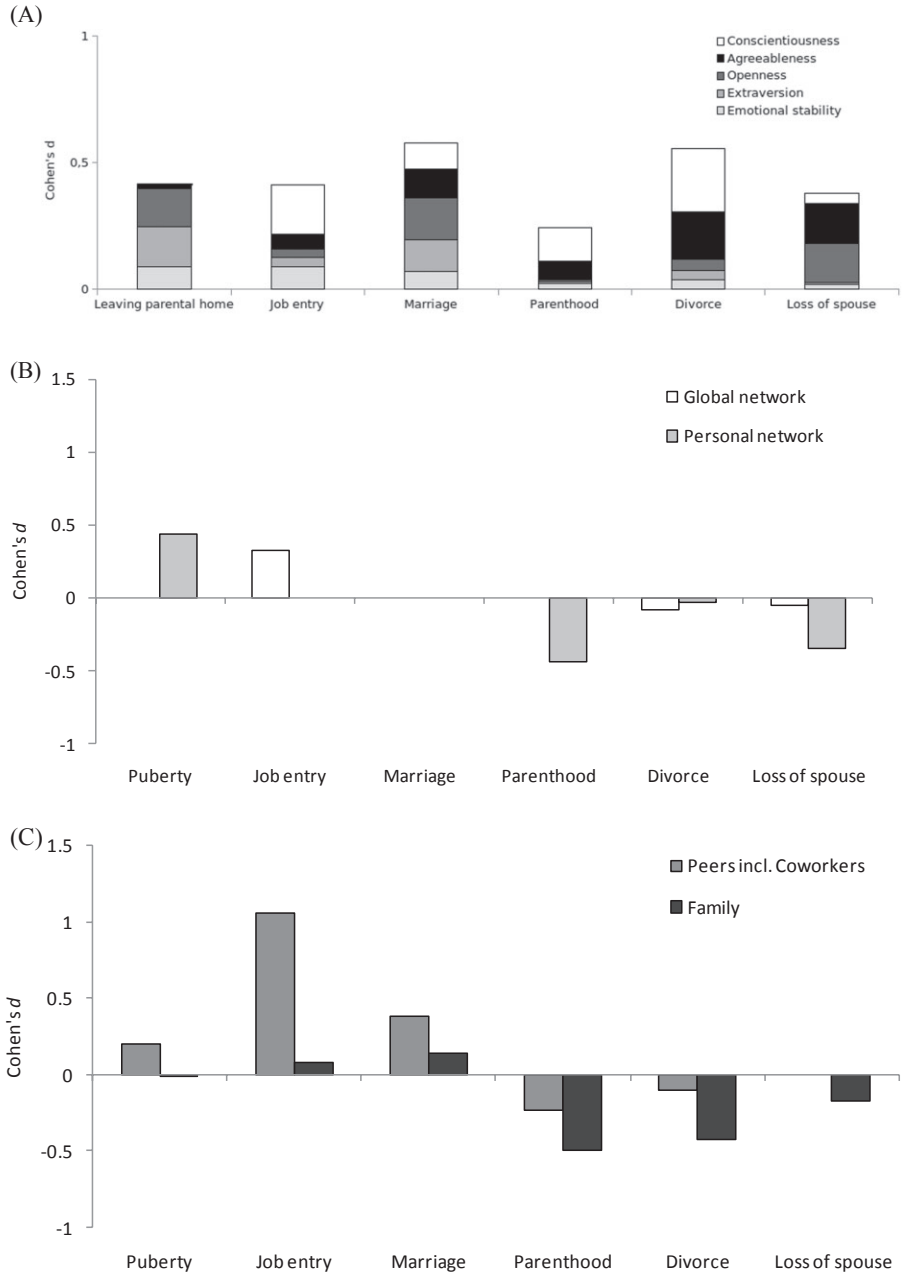

Figure 1 Absolute values of personality change (derived from Specht et al., 2011) (A), changes in personal and global network size (B), and peer and family network size (C) in relation to selected life transitions (derived from Wrzus et al., 2013). Standardized effect sizes (Cohen's *d*) are depicted.

romantic partners, and that these relationship types differ with regard to quality and stability (Neyer & Lang, 2003, 2013). However, the underlying processes and implications that these different relationships hold for the individual person are manifold, and controversy has ensued in their discussion. There are no consensual relationship taxonomies (like the Big Five factor model of personality) or broadband theoretical approaches—other than attachment or social exchange theories—that would permit unification of the field (see Neyer, Wrzus, Wagner, & Lang, 2011, for an overview and integration). It also comes as no surprise that social relationship development across the life span has likewise been understudied. In principle, studies on relationship development can take one of two broad perspectives. Relationship dynamics may reflect either qualitative changes in established relationships or quantitative fluctuations in social relationships (i.e., losses and gains of social relationships; Feld, Suitor, & Hoegh, 2007).

In view of the latter perspective, Wrzus, Hänel, Wagner, and Neyer (2013) showed in a recent meta-analysis that social networks generally increase across adolescence and young adulthood and then decrease steadily, mainly because peers and friends decrease in number, whereas the number of family relationships remains stable in size throughout life. These general patterns of social network change may certainly mask changes at more specific levels (e.g., families are composed differently depending on the specific life stage; Feld et al., 2007). Nonetheless, it is quite interesting to find that age-related changes in social network size mirror network changes that are due to rather normative life transitions such as parental transitions, job entry, widowhood, and others (Wrzus et al., 2013). Figure 1 also summarizes changes in social network size with regard to personal and global networks (i.e., networks including significant others and social networks in general; Panel B), and with regard to networks of social role relationships (i.e., peer and family relationships; Panel C). It can be seen that life events that occur primarily in young adulthood (Specht et al., 2011) are associated with network gains (e.g., marriage, job entry), whereas life transitions that become more prevalent with increasing age (Specht et al., 2011) include either voluntary or forced network declines, such as retirement or widowhood. An exception to this pattern is the transition to parenthood, which is usually followed by network shrinkage, for example, due to less available time and an increased focus on the spouse and the child (Bernardi, 2003).

We argue that similar to personality changes, network changes related to more normative life transitions are normative, i.e., both the pattern and timing of changes are similar across people. For example, job entry and marriage typically occur in young adulthood and require investments in new social roles, such as cooperation with colleagues and coming to terms with one's in-laws. By contrast, network changes related to less normative life transitions, such as divorce or relocation, do not follow normative age-graded trajectories (Wrzus et al., 2013) and leave more options for individual differences in change patterns. One can speculate that the corresponsive principle also applies to social network changes (i.e., certain network characteristics influence the occurrence of the life transition). For example, somebody with more friends is more likely to find a job quickly, and by engaging in the new job, will likely also increase his or her number of friends; however, this idea has yet to be studied.

Overall, we take these meta-analytic findings as evidence for our conception that life transitions occur together with or trigger relationship changes and are, first and foremost, "relationship transitions" (Neyer & Lehnart, 2007, p. 536). When comparing personality and social network changes (Figure 1, Panels A with B and C), it becomes apparent that all life transitions related to age-graded personality changes are accompanied by respective social network changes. Although these associations are merely observational, they may indicate that life transitions involving family relationships are primarily, but not exclusively, associated with changes in conscientiousness and agreeableness, whereas transitions involving changes in peer relationships mostly go hand in hand with changes in extraversion and openness. And indeed, some of these associations have been reported in longitudinal studies of personality-relationship transactions (e.g., Asendorpf & Wilpers, 1998; Neyer & Asendorpf, 2001; Parker, Lüdtke, Trautwein, & Roberts, 2012; Zimmermann & Neyer, 2013). Therefore, associations between life transitions and personality change can be viewed as resulting from transactions between social relationships and personality.

REVISITING PERSONALITY-RELATIONSHIP TRANSACTIONS

Earlier studies on personality-relationship transactions have concluded that adult personality traits are so stable that they have stronger effects on relationships than vice versa, and that relationship effects play only a minor role in personality development (Asendorpf & van Aken, 2003; Asendorpf & Wilpers, 1998; Neyer & Asendorpf, 2001; Parker et al., 2012). The main reason for these conclusions is that characteristics of relationships such as numbers of relationship partners and relationship qualities are less stable than personality traits over time. Therefore, personality traits are expected to have a greater chance of influencing change in relationships than vice versa. For example, extraversion is supposed to influence the long-term development of friendship networks such that highly extraverted people experience stronger increases than introverted people (Selfhout et al., 2010; see also Asendorpf & Wilpers, 1998, for similar effects of shyness). At the same time, extraversion is such a robust trait that it seems relatively immune to changes in relationships, such that extraverted people stay the same even if they face a negative experience such as social rejection. Examples such as these are frequently quoted to illustrate that people remain who they are despite the wide array of circumstances that may change their lives (Neyer & Wrzus, 2009).

As outlined above, we contend that the relative strengths of personality versus relationship effects depend on the context in which they take place. In line with Caspi and Moffitt's (1993) paradoxical theory, we hypothesize that relationship effects on personality development become stronger the more a given life transition conforms to a normative character. Conversely, we expect that personality effects become stronger the less normative a given life transition appears. Notwithstanding these ideas, in line with earlier empirical work on personality-relationship transactions, we expect that personality effects are generally stronger than relationship effects. Figure 2 illustrates this assumption, which we will discuss and illustrate below.

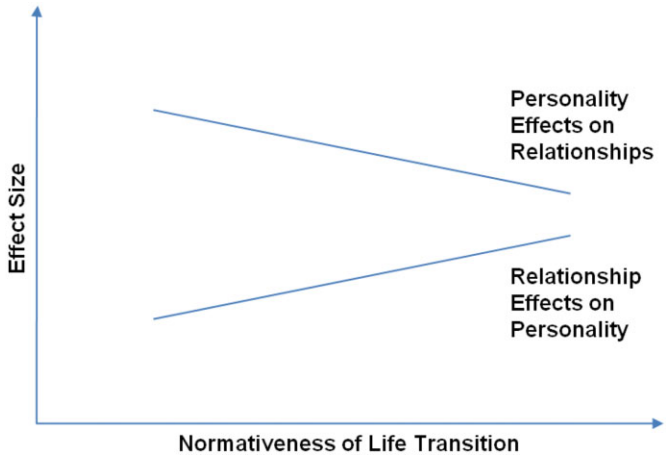

Figure 2 The relative strengths of personality versus relationship effects are expected to depend on the normativeness of life transitions.

Personality-Relationship Transactions in the Context of Rather Normative Life Transitions

More normative life experiences are characterized by strong social expectations that are communicated via the social context, that is, primarily by social relationship experiences and the relationship partners involved. For example, in Western cultures, most young adults want to engage in long-term romantic relationships. Cultural scripts that are shared by most of them depict how this common goal can be achieved by first meeting, then dating, and, finally, committing to a romantic partner. When young adults enter a romantic relationship for the first time, they have to make a new kind of commitment that they had not made in any other relationship before. In this way, the first romantic relationship is expected to facilitate a relationship effect on personality change. And indeed, research has repeatedly shown that this transition is associated with positive personality changes (Lehnart, Neyer, & Eccles, 2010; Neyer & Lehnart, 2007; Wagner, Lüdtke, Jonkmann, & Trautwein, 2013).

For example, Neyer and Lehnart (2007) conducted an 8-year longitudinal study on personality and relationship development with young German adults (the mean age of participants at the first assessment was 24.4 years; $SD = 3.7$). At the onset, it was observed that young singles (i.e., who had never had a romantic partner before) were characterized by a less desirable personality profile than their peers with partner experience (Neyer, 1999). In particular, they had higher levels of neuroticism and shyness and lower levels of extraversion, conscientiousness, and self-esteem. In a natural experiment, the personality development of stable singles was compared with timely beginners 4 years later and with late beginners 8 years later (i.e., former singles who had entered a partner relationship for the first time during the first or second measurement interval, respectively). It was found that both groups of beginners had experienced personality change, most notably a decline in neuroticism, and this change was attributed to the partnership experience. These findings were replicated with an 8-year longitudinal study from the United States that was largely comparable in terms of design and age group (the mean age at the first assessment was about 20.0 years; Lehnart et al., 2010). It was again found that compared to stable singles, the groups of timely and late beginners showed substantial decreases in facets of neuroticism such as depression and social anxiety. Moreover, it was observed in this study that remaining single for 8 years was related to decreases in self-esteem, especially for men. This finding suggests that the absence of investment in the role of a romantic partner may have detrimental effects on personality development. As the overall results were replicated within and between the two longitudinal studies, we conclude that there is now strong evidence that partnering can be considered one of the leading forces of personality development in the third decade of life, at least among young adults in the United States and Germany at the end of the 20th century.

Of course, normative life transitions also occur at later ages, for example, in midlife, when adult children leave their parental homes, people retire, or older parents die. These and other life transitions that are normative at certain ages are all essentially accompanied by normative changes in social networks and specific relationships (Lang et al., 2006; Wrzus et al., 2013). We therefore expect that they have the potential to initiate personality change despite their less scripted nature. Yet, this assumption awaits empirical support.

Personality-Relationship Transactions in the Context of Rather Non-Normative Life Transitions

Social relationships are also involved in life transitions that are less normative. Such rather non-normative life transitions offer greater opportunities for personality effects on both selection and adaptation, as they contain less uniform behavioral expectancies that are socially sanctified. The differential construal of these life transitions allows for a greater number of behavioral options, which gives rise to personality influences on socialization effects. One result is that these transitions contribute to cumulative personality stability rather than to personality change. The corresponsive principle as outlined above explains personality development in exactly this way.

For example, being deserted by one's partner is an event that is rather non-normative, as it is not tied to specific ages or equipped with specific scripts; for example, some people might be sad, whereas others might be relieved that the relationship ended. Because a person's behavior in such a situation is also less scripted in nature, it is very likely that people will react to such an event by reorganizing their social environments in accordance with their individual coping styles and other features of their personalities. Also, an active partnership breakup and engagement in a new one do not necessarily

induce personality change but are instead shaped by a person's individual personality (Lehnart & Neyer, 2006; Neyer & Asendorpf, 2001). Lehnart and Neyer (2006) compared the longitudinal associations of personality and attachment styles between young adults who either remained committed to the same romantic partner for more than 8 years (i.e., "continuers") or changed their partners at least once during this period (i.e., "changers"). Continuous reciprocal transactions appeared only in the group of continuers. Specifically, the continuous experience of a secure attachment relationship predicted increases in emotional stability, and emotional stability predicted increases in attachment security. By contrast, the group of changers demonstrated a one-way direction of effect such that personality traits predicted attachment styles in a new relationship, whereas attachment experiences in former relationships had no impact on later personality development. These results are instructive because they show that a short-term destabilization of the social environment (i.e., partner change) by no means leads to personality change. It rather seems that the "changers" tried to maintain stability by shaping their new relationships in ways that suited their personalities. By contrast, a stable partner relationship could be viewed as a stable environment in which continuous and reciprocal transactions can take place.

There are other less normative life transitions that involve relationships. For example, residential mobility is a life transition that is associated with certain relationship experiences, and these are at least partly selected by people with specific personality configurations (Jokela, 2009; Zimmermann & Neyer, 2013). Furthermore, people on the move experience profound declines in the overall size of their social networks (Wrzus et al., 2013), and these changes may influence further personality change. The study by Zimmermann and Neyer (2013) showed that relationship fluctuation is one of the multiple mechanisms of personality-relationship transactions. In their study, including 1,134 young adults in their early 20s, the trajectories of personality and relationship development were compared between student sojourners (i.e., students who spent either a semester or a full academic year on campuses abroad) and control students. It appeared at the onset of the study that long-term sojourners were more extraverted and more open compared to control students, and short-term sojourners were characterized by higher extraversion and conscientiousness (selection effects). Over the course of an academic year, substantial differences in trait development between both sojourner groups and control students became apparent. All sojourners revealed trends of increases in openness, stronger increases in agreeableness, and steeper declines in neuroticism than control students (socialization effects). In addition, the social support networks of sojourners showed strong fluctuations; that is, some support relationships were ended and new support relationships, most notably with international partners, were added. Relationship fluctuation was much smaller in control students, in particular with respect to international relationship gains. Zimmermann and Neyer (2013) analyzed multivariate mediation models assuming that relationship fluctuation serves as a powerful determinant of personality development in the context of international mobility. And indeed, results validated international relationship gains as a mechanism for explaining the effects of sojourning on changes in openness and neuroticism. The effects on openness nicely illustrate the conception of corresponsive personality development: Higher openness biased long-term sojourners toward self-selection into international mobility experiences, which led these students to initiate new support relationships with international partners, which in turn explained the further accentuation of their openness.

Mechanisms of Personality-Relationship Transactions

Given these considerations, we contend that personality effects and relationship effects are based on different mechanisms (Figure 3). On the one hand, relationships are assumed to affect personality via the commitment to social roles and the continuity of relationship experiences, as would be predicted by the social investment principle (Lodi-Smith & Roberts, 2007). That is, these relationship experiences do not appear out of nowhere but rather unfold in the context of more normative life transitions that require the commitment to social role expectations. In addition, these relationship experiences are not based on single events but become established in repeated patterns of interactions with relationship partners.

On the other hand, according to the corresponsive principle, we assume that personality effects work through the selection, maintenance, and change in relationships and their characteristics. For example, it is a well-established finding that neuroticism has at least modest effects on relationship satisfaction in romantic relationships (e.g., Dyrenforth, Kashy, Donnellan, & Lucas, 2010). These effects can most likely be explained by interactional, cognitive, and emotional processes. More recently, Finn, Mitte, and Neyer (2013) showed that the so-called relationship-specific interpretation bias fully

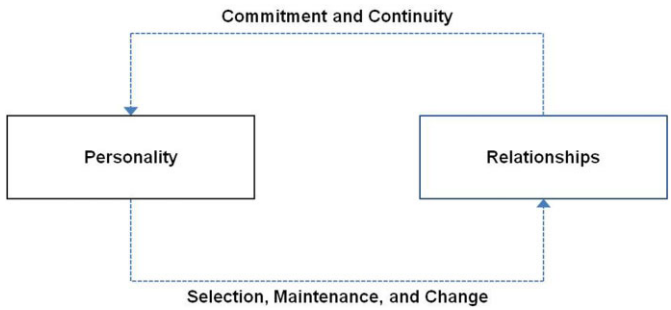

Figure 3 Conceptual model of personality-relationship transactions: Personality traits influence social relationship development mainly by the selection of, maintenance of, and change in relationships; social relationships influence personality development mostly by adaptations to social role expectations as they are reflected by relationship commitment and continuity.

mediates the effects of neuroticism on relationship satisfaction; that is, more neurotic individuals tend to interpret a given behavior of their partners in a rather threatening way and are therefore less satisfied with their relationships.

From a more general perspective, personality effects on social relationships are likely to occur in the context of less normative life experiences or transitions. These are less regulated by behavioral norms and are instead rather open to individual strategies and preferences. As personality effects on relationships reflect individual patterns of relationship regulation, these will contribute to the stability of individual differences across the life course. This is not to say that relationship experiences may not be strong. On the contrary, the most painful, frustrating, or overwhelming experiences befall us in close relationships. However, such unexpected experiences are less likely to set in motion personality change and rather are managed in line with the personality profiles that people bring to them. The examples above allude to the idea that well-being and health might be affected when life events occur. Next, we will argue that again, the normativeness of life transitions relates to how personality and relationship changes affect health.

PERSONALITY-RELATIONSHIP TRANSACTIONS AND HEALTH OUTCOMES

It is well established that personality traits have long-lasting influences on diverse health outcomes, such as well-being, self-perceived health status, adaptive personality development, and even longevity (Ozer & Benet-Martínez, 2006; Roberts, Kuncel, Shiner, Caspi, & Goldberg, 2007). Though the sizes of these effects may be small, they accumulate over time and may not only impair individual lives but also strain health-care systems. Whether health crises occur unexpectedly or foreseeably, we believe that the study of personality-relationship transactions offers insights into their etiology, particularly when the involved life transition is considered.

We argue that personality effects on health outcomes may be mediated by relationship processes, and likewise, that relationship effects on health outcomes may be mediated by personality processes (see Figure 4; Neyer & Lehnart, 2006). For instance, the well-known effects of neuroticism on health may be triggered by negative relationship experiences such as patterns of conflict in one's marriage, family, or workplace (e.g., Mroczek & Almeida, 2004). Similarly, the effects of relationship conflict on health may by partly mediated by personality processes such as biased information processing. For example, in an extensive meta-analysis, Mund and Mitte (2012) confirmed that a repressive coping style is associated with somatic diseases (e.g., increased blood pressure). We can only speculate here that a repressive coping style may canalize the assumed health-impairing effects of conflict-laden relationships. Having said that, however, it has to be acknowledged that personality and relationships may have independent effects on health outcomes as well, and these are also illustrated by the respective paths in Figure 4 (i.e., Personality→Personality→Health).

We propose that the impact of personality-relationship transactions on health outcomes also depends on the life transition that takes place. Assuming that relationship effects are important during more normative transitions, we expect that the indirect path from relationships to health outcomes via the effects of personality changes becomes particularly important (i.e., Relationships→Personality→Health path; see Figure 4). For example, establishing a steady romantic relationship or marriage is a rather normative life transition in young adulthood. The failure or the unwillingness to undergo the romantic partner transition in young adulthood may handicap personality maturation with even more negative consequences for a person's health and well-being in the long run (Lehnart et al., 2010). That is, remaining single throughout adulthood seems to be a risk factor for health impairment or even mortality, and it may qualify the well-known effects of neuroticism on health outcomes. Another implication of this idea is that the mastering of and adaptation to rather normative life events and transitions, such as puberty, depends more on characteristics of the social network than on personality traits. For instance, there is a large body of evidence that indicates that the onset or escalation of substance use in adolescence is influenced by both the behavior of one's parents and the characteristics of one's peers, in particular during the transition from one school to another (Brown, Mounts, Lamborn, & Steinberg, 1993; Jackson & Schulenberg, in press). A better quality of the parent-child relationship was also shown to be a protective factor against adolescent obesity during puberty (van Ryzin & Nowicka, 2013).

Yet, when facing less normative life transitions, the indirect path from personality to health outcomes via relationship experiences should become more powerful (i.e., Personality→Relationships→Health path; Figure 4). For example, people higher in neuroticism often experience lower well-being and health and are more prone to experiencing divorce (Kelly & Conley, 1987). The effects of divorce on health and well-being (Lucas, 2005; Luhmann & Eid, 2009)

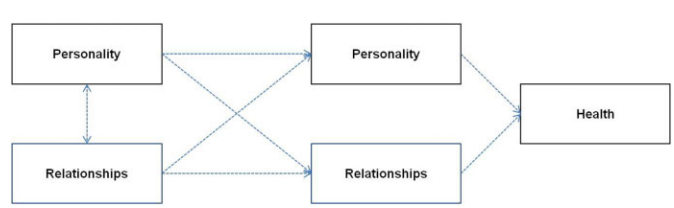

Figure 4 Personality-relationship transactions and health outcomes. Adapted from "Personality, Relationships, and Health: A Dynamic-Transactional Perspective" (p. 197), by F. J. Neyer and J. Lehnart, 2006, in M. E. Vollrath (Ed.), *Handbook of Personality and Health* (pp. 195–213). New York: John Wiley & Sons. Copyright 2006 by John Wiley & Sons Ltd. Adapted with permission.

may come about by decreases in social networks, especially with friends and acquaintances who were shared with the former partner (Wrzus et al., 2013). That is, having fewer friends to socialize with, confide in, and receive support from will directly affect well-being and health (Fiori, Antonucci, & Cortina, 2006; Hartup & Stevens, 1997; Pinquart & Sörensen, 2000; Wrzus, Wagner, & Neyer, 2012). But less normative life transitions also allow for the restructuring of the social network to better fit one's personality and new life circumstances. This, in turn, can promote health and well-being (van Tilburg, 1992; van Tilburg & Broese van Groenou, 2002).

METHODOLOGICAL CONSIDERATIONS

From a methodological point of view, further aspects should be considered. Longitudinal studies on personality-relationship transactions have typically used cross-lagged panel (CLP) designs (Asendorpf & van Aken, 2003; Asendorpf & Wilpers, 1998; Neyer & Asendorpf, 2001; Parker et al., 2012; also see Figure 4 in which the left part depicts a simplified version of a CLP design). These models require that personality traits as well as relationship features are studied at least twice over some period of time: Besides concurrent correlations, the cross-paths from personality to later relationships, and vice versa, are supposed to reflect direct effects, whereas correlated changes show the "common swinging" of both domains. As mentioned above, these studies have time and again observed the pattern of strong personality effects but negligible relationship effects.

More recently, Mund and Neyer (2013) readdressed this issue and investigated personality-relationship transactions in a 15-year longitudinal study covering the period from young adulthood to early midlife. The study included 654 young adults who were about 24 years old at the first assessment. Using a CLP design with three measurement occasions, they analyzed transactions between the Big Five traits and its facets (Saucier, 1998) and various qualities of different kinds of social network relationships, such as closeness, contact, conflict, and insecurity with friends, family, and others. A distinctive and innovative feature of these CLP models was that the cross-paths were simultaneously analyzed in two ways (Grimm, An, McArdle, Zonderman, & Resnick, 2012): one that predicted changes in personality or relationships by the preceding levels of the respective other characteristic (i.e., effects of level on later changes), and one that predicted change in one characteristic by the amount of preceding change in the other one (i.e., effects of change on later change). Using this strict analytical approach, Mund and Neyer (2013) found personality and relationship effects of comparable strength. This was particularly true for the personality facets, which turned out to be both more susceptible to environmental influences than the broad Big Five traits and more predictive of changes in the various relationship qualities. Additionally, multiple effects of correlated change between personality and relationships suggested a strong connection of change in the two domains, for instance, between increases in neuroticism and perceived insecurity with various members of one's social network. As correlated changes do not allow for conclusions about the direction of influence, the question of the relative powers of personality versus relationship effects remains open.

However, it is likely that conventional CLP designs tend to overlook substantial personality *and* relationship effects for several reasons. First, studies are only in very rare cases explicitly designed to be analyzed with CLP models. Thus, fitting a CLP model to data that do not meet its assumptions (e.g., equal distances between measurement occasions, comparable stability of constructs, all constructs measured at the same time; see Rogosa, 1980) might be theoretically inappropriate, and the results might not be trustworthy. Second, usually only a few cross-lagged paths are modeled over relatively long time periods. In order to fully capture dynamic transactions, studies with more measurement occasions and narrower time intervals are needed. Finally, they ignore contextual factors that may moderate personality-relationship transactions. We believe that the key to solving this issue is to consider the *contexts* in which transactions take place. In most cases, this is hardly possible in CLP models in a straightforward manner but could be achieved in several other ways: for example, by using multiple group structural equation models if it is known beforehand that groups of participants differ in the experience of a certain life transition (e.g., when the timing of one's retirement depends on one's job; when the transition to grandparenthood depends on having children or being childless). Alternatively, structural equation model decision trees (Brandmaier, von Oertzen, McArdle, & Lindenberger, 2013) offer an exploratory approach for identifying groups that differ in their personality-relationship transactional effects. As discussed above, we submit the hypothesis that the relative powers of personality versus relationship effects depend on the type of life transition in which they take place.

To address the role of life transitions as contexts of personality-relationship transactions, it would also be desirable to conduct more studies that include natural experiments or quasi-experiments (Rutter, 2007). For example, the longitudinal studies by Neyer and Lehnart (2007), Lehnart et al. (2010), and Zimmermann and Neyer (2013) are exemplary, as these studies compared the personality trajectories of transition and control groups such that selection and socialization processes could be disentangled. We are persuaded that natural experiments present an important approach to the study of personality-relationship transactions. However, we should add that natural experiments require replication before their results can be taken seriously and generalized (Asendorpf et al., 2013). We have shown that at least some of our recent findings are replicable, for example, the effects of partnering in young adulthood.

CONCLUSIONS

Individual lifestyles and circumstances can be described by the configuration of the social relationships that people initiate,

maintain, or end. That is to say, lifestyles and circumstances cannot be reduced to the presence or absence of single relationships. For example, partnered or single young adults differ not only with regard to the availability of a romantic partner but also with regard to other relationships in their social networks, and it is this set of relationships that reflects their lifestyles (Neyer, 1999). In addition, these diverse relationships change differently and have different meanings across the life course (Wrzus et al., 2013), thereby forming the social framework for personality development (Mund & Neyer, 2013; Neyer & Lehnart, 2007; Zimmermann & Neyer, 2013).

In this article, we have argued that transactions between personality and the diverse kinds of relationships have different consequences on personality development, depending on the life transition in which they take place. Specifically, we have claimed that personality effects on relationships are stronger the less normative a given life transition appears, whereas relationship effects on personality are stronger the more life transitions take on a normative character. Regarding health-related outcomes of personality-relationship transactions, this implies likewise that life transitions should be taken into account. This assumption reminds us of a Mischelian view of the relative powers of personality and situational effects on human behavior (Mischel, 1977). We believe it is worthwhile to integrate this perspective into theory and research on personality development and health.

Finally, there are some research desiderata that need to be addressed in the future. First, the normativeness of life events that provide the context of personality-relationship transactions must be explored in more detail. To the best of our knowledge, no comprehensive taxonomy has existed until now to allow for life transitions to be ranked according to their degree of normativeness. A taxonomy should be empirically based and should be able to account for the normativeness of life transitions with regard to age-related and sociocultural contexts. Second, longitudinal studies on personality-relationship transactions have to be complemented by more fine-grained studies on the day-to-day changes in relationships and self-regulation to develop a deeper understanding of the psychological processes that may explain long-term effects. Third, until now, research has focused on emerging and young adults only; thus, studies addressing personality-relationship transactions in middle and old age need to be conducted. And last but not least, our assumption about the moderating role of life transitions on the relative strengths of personality and relationship effects has received just preliminary support and needs in-depth exploration. We are eager to continue this work.

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